Nauroz, he institutionalized two occasions for annual charity, on his lunar and solar birthdays.

It began with yet another omen. At midday on 30 July 1582, one embankment of the artificial lake above Fatehpur collapsed. The lake, two miles long and half a mile wide, not only provided water to the city, but also 'when the sun gets low in the sky . . . a cool and pleasant breeze'.[22]

Unsurprisingly, it was a popular spot for picnics, people gathering for games of parcheesi, chess and cards; even Akbar coming by 'on holidays, [to refresh] himself with its many beauties'.[23] It is lucky, then, that when the great lake's waters burst, only one man, a cheetah-keeper called Madadi, died in the flood. Many were injured, however, and the gushing waters even swept away houses.

It was a sign of divine displeasure with 'this business of recreation' on the lakeside, said Akbar. In atonement, he ordered his court – or possibly his empire, Abul Fazl doesn't specify – to forgo meat on the 30th of every month; and, to further demonstrate that he had heard and heeded God's advice, he announced that he would, henceforth, be weighed on his solar and lunar birthdays, against twelve and eight kinds of goods, respectively, ranging from gold and silk to ghee and salt, plants and grain to sweets and incense, all of it to be given away.[24]

By contrast, Akbar had introduced the system of escheat in 1575, by which the crown inherited an amir's estate on his demise. The first of Akbar's noblemen to suffer such posthumous appropriation of his wealth was Munim Khan: when the aged Chagatai died in the winter of 1575, everything he owned 'reverted' to the state. His wife, it seems, was left without even the means to pay for the rituals of mourning.[25] Similarly, when poor Makhdum-ul-Mulk died of fright upon his arrest in Gujarat, Akbar took every last penny of his accumulated treasures. The avaricious old man had hidden gold in his own tomb, writes Badauni; 'boxes full of ingots of gold were discovered
. . . where he had caused them to be buried as corpses'. The once-powerful cleric's sons, Badauni continues, not without satisfaction, fell into 'the most abject poverty' when Akbar took their inheritance.[26]

Akbar was taking, quite literally, from the rich, and he was giving to the poor. However, just as Akbar's concern for his subjects was not restricted to